

While being minimal and simplistic, Etiole allows for a very high level of customisability. Enlightenment is another pretty boy desktop environment, also lightweight, used as a default in the OpenGEU distro. Unique features include grouping windows together to perform the same operations on them (you can resize your browser, your word processor and your chat client at the same time) and the ability to strip windows of borders and buttons. Blackbox is a large, open desktop environment, with emphasis on being lightweight. Fluxxbox and Openbox are derivatives of Blackbox. Ion is the geek's desktop environment, allowing for efficient navigation for the keyboard warrior. Ion is also very lightweight, minimal (there is no start menu by default) and blocky.

Linux mythbusting

There are a lot of Linux myths floating around, and by and large, it is one of the most misunderstood operating systems around. Linux is not better than Windows. No one can claim that Linux is faster or Windows is faster. There is a threshold speed at which computer users can operate a system, to start off with and you really cannot go beyond that. Though it is true that Windows uses far more system resources than a Linux distribution, Linux simply does not do everything that a Windows system does. Games are just a starting point, although KDE or XFCE are elegant desktop environments, they really is no free desktop environment that comes close to what Windows Vista's Aero or OS X's Aqua have to offer. It is true that Linux can be used to effectively salvage an old computer, you won't be able to do too much with it. For example, advanced operations on Gimp will be much slower on an old computer, and many desktop environments and distros simply will not run on anything less than 256 MB of RAM, which is supposedly one of the greatest plus points of Linux. The transition from Windows to Linux is not smooth at all, no matter what you might have heard. OpenOffice.org has as much feature bloat as Microsoft Office, and there are many subtle changes in the behavior of these office suites that will definitely reduce productivity after taking the plunge. Moreover, it is simply not true that Gimp or OpenOffice.org come anywhere close to the functionality of the latest releases of Photoshop and MS Office.

Another big myth is that Linux is free. There are a lot of Free distributions available, but many of them charge for support (even popular ones like Ubuntu, Mandriva and SUSE have commercial